

LITTLE BLUE BOOK NO. 735
Edited by E. Haldeman-Julius

Confessions of St. Augustine

**Edited, with Introduction, by
Lloyd E. Smith**

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OF ST. AUGUSTINE ***

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INTRODUCTION

Saint Augustine, “one of the four great fathers of the Latin Church,” was born in what is now Algeria (North Africa), November, 354 A. D. His mother was a devout Christian, but his father was unconverted at the time of Augustine’s birth. The piety of the mother finally won both father and son to the Christian faith.

Augustine’s early life, especially his youth, was characterized by sinful lapses into the evils of temptation, temptation to which he often yielded, for which weakness he has chastised himself mercilessly in his *Confessions*. His self-condemned wickedness did not prevent his being a determined student, however, and he was carefully trained to become a teacher of rhetoric. At nineteen, his mind was stirred by Cicero’s *Hortensius* to seek the truth, but he wandered aimlessly about in the mazes of various schools of thought without adopting any one of them, good or bad. Manicheism (a religious philosophy in which goodness and light, identified with God, were in conflict with evil and chaos, identified with the powers of darkness) attracted Augustine, until he became an enthusiastic exponent of its doctrines. He hoped that his own dark path of sensuality might be directed to the light by the influence of this oriental system (Manicheism originated in Persia and had a bright coloring of eastern myth), but he had not acquired sufficient moral strength to enable him to attain his ideal of chastity and temperance. Because it did not lead him out of his evil ways, as he had hoped, Manicheism gradually weakened in its sway over him. Then, too, Augustine was well-versed in the exact sciences, and so found it impossible to coordinate the superstitions of Manicheism with known facts.

Augustine, became a teacher of grammar, was, by all accounts, an excellent instructor. He returned to his birthplace, and, while teaching there, secured the lasting friendship of Alypius. Staying here about a year—the chief happening, besides his friendship with Alypius, being a vision of his mother

comforting her for her son's lack of faith, described in the *Confessions* (III, xi)—Augustine went back to Carthage, and from there to Rome. This was in 383; but Rome, since his interest in Manicheism was on the wane, held little attraction for him, so he accepted a position as teacher of rhetoric at Milan.

Now openly separated from Manicheism, Augustine turned to Skepticism (Pyrrhonism: disbelief in all doctrines and principles derived from either the reason or the senses; the judgment was to be kept in aloof non-committal on all subjects) temporarily, and from that to Neo-Platonism (involving that all matter was evil, that all ideas were emanations from the mind of God, that human reason was in affinity with Divine reason, that the soul was to be redeemed by separation from matter, and that the human reason was to be absorbed in the divine by “continuous contemplation;” it professed a trinity composed of the One, Intelligence, and the Soul) which gave him his first hint of a God minus materialism: invisible, eternal, and changeless. A devout preacher of Milan further influenced him in this trend toward faith, and his battle with the curse of sensuality that was upon him became an intolerable conflict within him.

His struggle toward truth culminated in one poignant moment of realization, which he has described in the *Confessions* (VIII, xii, 30). This conversion occurred in 386, when he withdrew, accompanied by several friends, to a country place near Milan and offered himself as a candidate for baptism. Augustine's mother rejoiced at this fulfilment of her vision, and, when she was dying soon after this realization of her life-long hopes, her last hours of life were made happy by her son's Christian understanding. The account of their companionship in the *Confessions* (IX, x-xi, 23-28) displays Augustine's “literary power at its highest.”

Unwilling to assume religious responsibility in any official capacity too soon, Augustine, within a year, was persuaded to become presbyter of Hippo (now Bona, Algiers), and about 395 he became coadjutor to the bishop, and subsequently bishop of the see. The remaining years of his life were occupied with his ecclesiastical duties, and by prolific writing, which was largely controversial. His *Confessions*, consisting of an autobiographical record of his spiritual conversion and growth, are his most famous achievement, and were written about 397. Probably his greatest work, from the point of view of intellectual as well as literary power, is the

City of God, begun in 413 and continuing over a period of thirteen years, which was planned as an elaborate treatise “in vindication of Christianity and the Christian Church.” In 427 he wrote the *Retractions*, which are a review of all his literary work, and include revisions, corrections, explanations, etc., to bring them all into line with the maturity of mind to which he had then attained. A work entitled *The Trinity* occupied him for some thirty years, and was not, as most of his writings were, inspired by the strife of religious controversy, but was the result of steady growth by contemplation in the author’s pious mind. These four, here named, are by no means all that Augustine wrote, but they serve to indicate his remarkable devotion and energy in his life of faith, a faith which came to him, a self-flailed sinner, as a remarkable sign of redemption.

Augustine died, sick and weary, while the Vandals were besieging Hippo, in 430, at seventy-five years of age. He did not live to see the city in the hands of its conquerors. “None can deny the greatness of Augustine’s soul—his enthusiasm, his unceasing search after truth, his affectionate disposition, his ardor, his self-devotion. And even those who may doubt the soundness of his dogmatic conclusions, cannot but acknowledge the depth of his spiritual convictions, and the logical force and penetration with which he handled the most difficult questions, thus weaving all the elements of his experience and of his profound scriptural knowledge into a great system of Christian thought.” (Gustav Krüger.)

The present edition has been based on the translation of E. B. Pusey, which first appeared in 1838, and of which Pusey speaks in his Preface: “The *Confessions* of St. Augustine have ever been a favorite Christian study. St. Augustine says of them himself, ‘The thirteen books of my Confessions praise God, Holy and Good, on occasion of that which has in me been good or evil, and raise up man’s understanding and affections to Him: for myself, they did so while they were being written, and now do, when read. Let others think of them, as to them seems right; yet that they have and do much please many brethren, I know.’” Pusey says further: “The subject of the *Confessions* would naturally give them a deep interest, presenting, as they do, an account of the way in which God led perhaps the most powerful mind of Christian antiquity out of darkness to light, and changed one who was a chosen vessel unto Himself from a heretic and a seducer of the brethren, into one of the most energetic defenders of Catholic Truth, both

against the strange sect to which he had belonged, and against the Arians, Pelagians, and semi-Pelagians, Donatists, Priscillianists. Such, not an autobiography, is the object of the *Confessions*; a praise and confession of God's unmerited goodness, but of himself only so much as might illustrate out of what depth God's mercy had raised him."

CONFESSIONS OF ST. AUGUSTINE

BOOK I

(i) 1. *Great art Thou, O Lord, and greatly to be praised; great is Thy power, and Thy wisdom infinite.* Thee would man praise; man, but a particle of Thy creation; man, that bears about him his mortality, the witness of his sin, the witness that *Thou resistest the proud*: yet would man praise Thee; he, but a particle of Thy creation. Thou awakest us to delight in Thy praise; for Thou madest us for Thyself, and our heart is restless until it repose in Thee. Grant me, Lord, to know and understand which is first, to call on Thee or to praise Thee? and, again, to know Thee or to call on Thee? For who can call on Thee, not knowing Thee? For he that knoweth Thee not may call on Thee as other than Thou art. Or is it rather that we call on Thee that we may know Thee? But *how shall they call on Him in whom they have not believed? or how shall they believe without a preacher? And they that seek the Lord shall praise Him. For they that seek shall find Him*, and they that find shall praise Him. I will seek Thee, Lord, by calling on Thee; and will call on Thee, believing in Thee; for to us hast Thou been preached. My faith, Lord, shall call on Thee, which Thou hast given me, wherewith Thou hast inspired me, through the Incarnation of Thy Son, through the ministry of the Preacher.^[1]

(ii) 2. And how shall I call upon my God, my God and Lord, since, when I call for Him, I shall be calling Him to myself? and what room is there within me whither my God can come into me? Whither can God come into me, God who made heaven and earth? Is there, indeed, O Lord my God, aught in me that can contain Thee? Do then heaven and earth, which Thou hast made, and wherein Thou hast made me, contain Thee? or, because nothing which exists could exist without Thee, doth therefore whatever exists contain Thee? Since, then, I too exist, why do I seek that Thou shouldst enter into me, who were not, wert Thou not in me? Why? Because I am not gone down in hell, and yet Thou art there also. For *if I go down*

into hell, Thou art there. I could not be, then, O my God, could not be at all, wert Thou not in me; or, rather, unless I were in Thee, *of whom are all things, by whom are all things, in whom are all things?* Even so, Lord, even so. Whither do I call Thee, since I am in Thee? or whence canst Thou enter into me? For whither can I go beyond heaven and earth, that thence my God should come into me, who hath said, *I fill the heaven and the earth?*

(iv) 4. What art Thou then, my God? What but the Lord God? *For who is Lord but the Lord? or who is God save our God?* Most highest, most good, most potent, most omnipotent; most merciful, yet most just; most hidden, yet most present; most beautiful, yet most strong; stable, yet incomprehensible; unchangeable, yet all-changing; never new, never old; all-renewing, and *bringing age upon the proud, and they know it not;* ever working, ever at rest; still gathering, yet nothing lacking; supporting, filling, and over-spreading; creating, nourishing, and maturing; seeking, yet having all things. Thou lovest, without passion; art jealous, without anxiety; repentest, yet grieveest not; art angry, yet serene; changest Thy works, Thy purpose unchanged; receivest again what Thou findest, yet didst never lose; never in need, yet rejoicing in gains; never covetous, yet exacting usury. Thou receivest over and above, that Thou mayest owe; and who hath aught that is not Thine? Thou payest debts, owing nothing; remittest debts, losing nothing. And what have I now said, my God, my life, my holy joy? or what saith any man when he speaks of Thee? Yet woe to him that speaketh not, since mute are even the most eloquent.

(v) 5. Oh! that I might repose on Thee! Oh! that Thou wouldst enter into my heart, and inebriate it, that I may forget my ills, and embrace Thee, my sole good?...

6. Narrow is the mansion of my soul; enlarge Thou it, that Thou mayest enter in. It is ruinous; repair Thou it. It has that within which must offend Thine eyes; I confess and know it. But who shall cleanse it? or to whom should I cry, save Thee?...

(vi) 7. Yet suffer me to speak unto Thy mercy, me, *dust and ashes.* Yet suffer me to speak, since I speak to Thy mercy, and not to scornful man. Thou too, perhaps, despisest me, yet wilt Thou *return and have compassion* upon me....

(He gives a detailed account of his infancy and boyhood, placing particular emphasis on the natural benefits derived from God, and laying repentant stress on the sins of which he was guilty. "As a boy I had already heard of an eternal life, promised us through the humility of the Lord our God stooping to our pride." But he was rebellious against the commands of his elders, nevertheless. He was forced to study the classics, to become acquainted therein with men who boasted of and were praised for their dissolution. "These are indeed his [Homer's] fictions; but attributing a divine nature to wicked men that crimes might be no longer crimes, and whoso commits them might seem to imitate not abandoned men, but the celestial gods [that is, the gods, passionate and sensual, have been dismissed by some as merely 'fictions' of Homer].")

BOOK II

(i) 1. I will now call to mind my past foulness, and the carnal corruptions of my soul: not because I love them, but that I may love Thee, O my God. For love of Thy love I do it; reviewing my most wicked ways in the very bitterness of my remembrance, that Thou mayest grow sweet unto me; and gathering me again out of that my dissipation, wherein I was torn piecemeal, while turned from Thee, the One Good, I lost myself among a multiplicity of things....

(In his sixteenth year, lured on by the praise of sin common in the company of young men with whom he associated, he seduced a girl—and subsequently became the father of an illegitimate son, whom he loved greatly. “To whom tell I this? not to Thee, my God; but before Thee to mine own kind, even to that small portion of mankind as may light upon these writings of mine. And to what purpose? that whosoever reads this may think *out of what depths we are to cry unto Thee*. For what is nearer to Thine ears than a confessing heart, and a life of faith?” His parents did not help him, did not seek to have him marry: “Neither did the mother of my flesh, as she advised me to chastity, so heed what she had heard of me from her husband as to restrain within the bounds of conjugal affection what she felt to be pestilent at present, and for the future dangerous. She heeded not this, for she feared lest a wife should prove a clog and hindrance to my hopes. Not those hopes of the world to come, which my mother reposed in Thee; but the hope of learning, which both my parents were too desirous I should attain; my father, because he had next to no thought of Thee, and of me but vain conceits; my mother, because she accounted that those usual courses of learning would not only be no hindrance, but even some furtherance towards attaining Thee.”)

(In addition, he commits theft for the sake of theft, stealing some pears for the pure joy of stealing—for they did not eat the pears. “They” were the

group in which he acted this part: he insists that he would never have stolen had he been alone.)

(vi) 12. What then did wretched I so love in thee, thou theft of mine, thou deed of darkness, in that sixteenth year of my age? Lovely thou wert not, because thou wert theft. But art thou anything, that thus I speak to thee? Fair were the pears we stole, because they were Thy creation, Thou fairest of all, Creator of all, Thou good God; God, the sovereign good and my true good. Fair were those pears, but not them did my wretched soul desire; for I had store of better, and those I gathered only that I might steal. For, when gathered, I flung them away, my only feast therein being my own sin, which I was pleased to enjoy. For if aught of those pears came within my mouth, what sweetened it was sin. And now, O Lord my God, I inquire what in that theft delighted me; and behold it hath no loveliness; I mean not such loveliness as in justice and wisdom; nor such as is in the mind and memory, and senses, and animal life of man; nor yet as the stars are glorious and beautiful in their orbs; or the earth, or sea, full of embryo-life, replacing by its birth that which decayeth; nay, nor even that false and shadowy beauty which belongeth to deceiving vices.

(vii) 15. *What shall I render unto the Lord*, that, whilst my memory recalls these things, my soul is not affrighted at them? *I will love Thee, O Lord, and thank Thee, and confess unto Thy name*; because Thou hast forgiven me these so great and heinous deeds of mine. To Thy grace I ascribe it, and to Thy mercy, that Thou hast melted away my sins as it were ice. To Thy grace I ascribe also whatsoever I have not done of evil; for what might I not have done, who even loved a sin for its own sake? Yea, all I confess to have been forgiven me; both what evils I committed by my own wilfulness, and what by Thy guidance I committed not. What man is he, who, weighing his own infirmity, dares to ascribe his purity and innocence to his own strength; that so he should love Thee the less, as if he had less needed Thy mercy, whereby Thou remittest sins to those that turn to Thee? For whosoever, called by Thee, followed Thy voice, and avoided those things which he read me recalling and confessing of myself, let him not scorn me, who being sick was cured by that Physician, through Whose aid it was that he was not, or rather was less, sick: and for this let him love Thee as much, yea and more; since by Whom he sees me to have been recovered from such deep

consumption of sin, by Him he sees himself to have been from the like
consumption of sin preserved.

BOOK III

(He resides at Carthage from his seventeenth to nineteenth year; he reads and is strongly influenced by Cicero's *Hortensius*; he is attracted to the Manicheans. Confessing a love of shows and fiction in which the passions of life are simulated, he repents his lack of interest in the Scriptures at this period.)

(xi) 19. And Thou *sentest Thine hand from above*, and drewest my soul out of that profound darkness, my mother, Thy faithful one, weeping to Thee for me, more than mothers weep the bodily deaths of their children. For she, by that faith and spirit which she had from Thee, discerned the death wherein I lay, and Thou heardest her, O Lord; Thou heardest her, and despisedst not her tears, when streaming down they watered the ground under her eyes^[2] in every place where she prayed; yea Thou heardest her. For whence was that dream whereby Thou comfortedst her; so that she allowed me to live with her, and to eat at the same table in the house, which she had begun to shrink from, abhorring and detesting the blasphemies of my error? For she saw herself standing on a certain wooden rule, and a shining youth coming towards her, cheerful and smiling upon her, herself grieving, and overwhelmed with grief. But he having (in order to instruct, as is their wont, not to be instructed) inquired of her the causes of her grief and daily tears, and she answering that she was bewailing my perdition, he bade her rest contented, and told her to look and observe, "That where she was, there was I also." And when she looked, she saw me standing by her in the same rule. Whence was this, but that Thine ears were towards her heart? O Thou Good omnipotent, who so carest for every one of us, as if Thou caredst for him only; and so for all, as if they were but one!

20. Whence was this also, that when she had told me this vision, and I would fain bend it to mean, "That she rather should not despair of being one day what I was;" she presently, without any hesitation, replies, "No; for it

was not told me that, ‘where he, there thou also;’ but ‘where thou, there he also?’” I confess to Thee, O Lord, that to the best of my remembrance, (and I have oft spoken of this), that Thy answer, through my waking mother,—that she was not perplexed by the plausibility of my false interpretation, and so quickly saw what was to be seen, and which I certainly had not perceived, before she spake,—even then moved me more than the dream itself, by which a joy to the holy woman, to be fulfilled so long after, was, for the consolation of her present anguish, so long before fore-signified. For almost nine years passed, in which I wallowed in the mire of that deep pit, and the darkness of falsehood, often assaying to rise, but dashed down the more grievously. All which time that chaste, godly, and sober widow, (such as Thou lovest), now more cheered with hope, yet no whit relaxing in her weeping and mourning, ceased not at all hours of her devotions to bewail my case unto Thee. And her *prayers entered into Thy presence*; and yet Thou sufferest me to be yet involved and reinvolved in that darkness.

(His mother attempts to persuade a bishop to convert her son, but the bishop explains that he is not yet ready for the faith, and that when he is, he will follow it himself. “Go thy ways, and God bless thee, for it is not possible that the son of these tears should perish.”)

BOOK IV

(For nine years, from his nineteenth to his twenty-eighth year, Augustine continues in his erring ways; “himself a Manichean and seducing others to the same heresy; partial obedience amidst vanity and sin, consulting astrologers, only partially shaken herein; loss of an early friend, who is converted by being baptized when in a swoon.”)

(v) 10. And now, Lord, these things are passed by, and time hath assuaged my wound. May I learn from Thee, who art Truth, and approach the ear of my heart unto Thy mouth, that Thou mayest tell me why weeping is sweet to the miserable? Hast Thou, although present everywhere, cast away our misery far from Thee? And Thou abidest in Thyself, but we are tossed about in divers trials. And yet unless we mourned in Thine ears, we should have no hope left. Whence then is sweet fruit gathered from the bitterness of life, from groaning, tears, sighs, and complaints? Doth this sweeten it, that we hope Thou hearest? This is true of prayer, for therein is a longing to approach unto Thee. But it is also in grief for a thing lost, and the sorrow wherewith I was then overwhelmed? For I neither hoped he should return to life, nor did I desire this with my tears; but I wept only and grieved. For I was miserable, and had lost my joy. Or is weeping indeed a bitter thing, and for very loathing of the things, which we before enjoyed, does it then, when we shrink from them, please us?

(vi) 11. But what speak I of these things? for now is no time to question, but to confess unto Thee. Wretched I was; and wretched is every soul bound by the friendship of perishable things; he is torn asunder when he loses them, and then he feels the wretchedness, which he had ere he lost them. So was it then with me; I wept most bitterly, and found my repose in bitterness. Thus was I wretched, and that wretched life I held dearer than my friend. For though I would willingly have changed it, yet was I more unwilling to part with it, than with him; yea, I know not whether I would have parted with it

even for him. In me there had arisen some unexplained feeling, too contrary to this, for at once I loathed exceedingly to live, and feared to die. I suppose, the more I loved him, the more did I hate, and fear (as a most cruel enemy) death, which had bereaved me of him: and I imagined it would speedily make an end of all men, since it had power over him. For I wondered that others, subject to death, did live, since he whom I loved, as if he should never die, was dead: and I wondered yet more that myself, who was to him a second self, could live, he being dead. Well said, one of his friend, "Thou half of my soul:" for I felt that my soul and his soul were "one soul in two bodies:" and therefore was my life a horror to me, because I would not live halved. And therefore perchance I feared to die, lest he whom I had much loved, should die wholly.

(viii) 13. Yet there succeeded, not indeed other griefs, yet the causes of other griefs. For whence had that former grief so easily reached my very inmost soul, but that I had poured out my soul upon the dust, in loving one that must die, as if he would never die? For what restored and refreshed me chiefly was the solaces of other friends, with whom I did love, what instead of Thee I loved; and this was a great fable, and protracted lie, by whose adulterous stimulus, our soul, which lay itching in our ears, was being defiled. But that fable would not die to me, so oft as any of my friends died. There were other things which in them did more take my mind; to talk and jest together, to do kind offices by turns; to read together honied books; to play the fool or be earnest together; to dissent at times without discontent, as a man might with his own self; and even with the seldomness of these dissentings, to season our more frequent consentings; sometimes to teach, and sometimes learn; long for the absent with impatience: and welcome the coming with joy. These and the like expressions, proceeding out of the hearts of those that loved and were loved again, by the countenance, the tongue, the eyes, and a thousand pleasing gestures, were so much fuel to melt our souls together, and out of many make but one.

(ix) 14. This is it that is loved in friends; and so loved, that a man's conscience condemns itself if he love not him that loves him again, or love not again him that loves him, looking for nothing from his person but indications of his love. Hence that mourning, if one die, and darkenings of sorrows, that steeping of the heart in tears, all sweetness turned to bitterness; and upon the loss of life of the dying, the death of the living.

Blessed whoso loveth Thee, and his friend in Thee, and his enemy for Thee. For he alone loses none dear to him, to whom all are dear in Him Who cannot be lost....

(xiv) 22. So did I then love men, upon the judgment of men, not thine, O my God, in Whom no man is deceived. But yet why not for qualities like those of a famous charioteer, or fighter with beasts in the theater, known far and wide by a vulgar popularity, but far otherwise, and earnestly, and so as I would be myself commended? For I would not be commended or loved, as actors are, (though I myself did commend and love them,) but had rather be unknown, than so known; and even hated, than so loved. Where now are the impulses to such various and divers kinds of loves laid up in one soul? Why, since we are equally men, do I love in another what, if I did not hate, I should not spurn and cast from myself? For it holds not, that as a good horse is loved by him who would not, though he might, be that horse, therefore the same may be said of an actor, who shares our nature. Do I then love in a man what I hate to be, who am a man? Man himself is a great deep, whose very *hairs Thou numberest*, O Lord, *and they fall not to the ground without Thee*. And yet are the hairs of his head easier to be numbered than are his feelings, and the beatings of his heart.

23. But there was an orator of that sort whom I loved as wishing to be myself such; and I erred through a swelling pride, and *was tossed about with every wind*, but yet was steered by Thee, though very secretly. And whence do I know, and whence do I confidently confess unto Thee, that I had loved him more for the love of his commenders, than for the very things for which he was commended? Because, had he been unpraised, and these self-same men had dispraised him, and with dispraise and contempt told the very same things of him, I had never been so kindled and excited to love him. And yet the things had not been other, nor he himself other; but only the feelings of the relators. See where the impotent soul lies along, that is not yet stayed up by the solidity of truth! Just as the gales of tongues blow from the breast of the opinionative, so is it carried this way and that, driven forward and backward, and the light is overclouded to it, and the truth unseen. And lo, it is before us. And it was to me a great matter that my discourse and labors should be known to that man: which should he approve, I were the more kindled; but if he disapproved, my empty heart, void of Thy solidity, had been wounded.

(Augustine confesses himself unable even to apply his knowledge and talents rightly without proper notions of God.)

BOOK V

(Augustine's twenty-ninth year: due to his knowledge of scientific subjects, he has begun to question many Manichean doctrines, and he is told that one Faustus, an eloquent defender of this sect, will remove all his doubts. This Faustus, however, in spite of his eloquence, fails to convince Augustine; on the contrary, he serves to expose even more the falsity of Manichean tenets. Augustine leaves Carthage for Rome, the better to continue his work in rhetoric, but in Rome he finds the distractions greater than he expected, so accepts a position as teacher of rhetoric in Milan. Here he meets Ambrose, the bishop who first shows him the way to divine truth—he is interested first, not by what Ambrose says, but by how he says it; yet, in the nature of things, he cannot entirely escape paying some attention to the thought as well as to the vehicle carrying it. Augustine therefore becomes a catechumen, or “beginner,” in the Catholic Church.)

(vi) 10. ... I now learned that neither ought anything to seem to be spoken truly, because eloquently; nor therefore falsely, because the utterance of the lips is inharmonious; nor, again, therefore true, because rudely delivered; nor therefore false, because the language is rich; but that wisdom and folly are as wholesome and unwholesome food; and adorned or unadorned phrases, as courtly or country vessels; either kind of meats may be served up in either kind of dishes.

BOOK VI

(Augustine's mother, whom he had left at Carthage when he departed for Rome, arrives to join him at Milan. She is pleased by his start on the right road, and redoubles her prayers for his ultimate conversion. Augustine is gradually progressing toward this culmination of his mother's hopes, but he is continually assailed by doubts. He is troubled by the worldly pursuits he has indulged in so long. His friend, Alypius, become a devotee of the contests and games in the Circus, is saved from this passionate dissipation by the God to whom Augustine looks for final salvation. But, indicative of his imprisonment in earthly pleasures, Augustine plans to marry, to enable himself to continue his carnal lusts under the protection of a legal union; he is dissuaded by his friends, with whom he discusses, at some length, their mode of life. Because of these "inveterate sins," Augustine lives in dread of divine judgment.)

BOOK VII

(i) 1. Deceased was now that my evil and abominable youth, and I was passing into early manhood [his thirty-first year]; the more defiled by vain things as I grew in years, who could not imagine any substance but such as is wont to be seen with these eyes. I thought not of Thee, O God, under the figure of a human body; since I began to hear aught of wisdom, I always avoided this; and rejoiced to have found the same in the faith of our spiritual mother, Thy Catholic Church. But what else to conceive Thee I knew not. And I, a man, and such a man, sought to conceive of Thee the sovereign, only, true God; and I did in my inmost soul believe that Thou wert incorruptible, and uninjurable, and unchangeable; because though not knowing whence or how, yet I saw plainly and was sure that that which may be corrupted must be inferior to that which cannot; what could not be injured I preferred unhesitatingly to what could receive injury; the unchangeable to things subject to change. My heart passionately cried out against all my phantoms, and with this one blow I sought to beat away from the eye of my mind all that unclean troop, which buzzed around it. And lo, being scarce put off, in the twinkling of an eye they gathered again thick about me, flew against my face, and beclouded it; so that though not under the form of the human body, yet was I constrained to conceive of Thee (that incorruptible, uninjurable, and unchangeable, which I preferred before the corruptible, and injurable, and changeable) as being in space, whether infused into the world, or diffused infinitely without it. Because whatsoever I conceived, deprived of this space, seemed to me nothing, yea altogether nothing, not even a void, as if a body were taken out of its place, and the place should remain empty of any body at all, of earth and water, air and heaven, yet would it remain a void place, as it were a specious nothing.

2. I then being thus gross-hearted, nor clear even to myself, whatsoever was not extended over certain space, nor diffused, nor condensed, nor swelled out, or did not or could not receive some of these dimensions, I thought to

be altogether nothing. For over such forms as my eyes are wont to range did my heart then range: nor yet did I see that this same notion of the mind, whereby I formed those very images, was not of this sort, and yet it could not have formed them, had not itself been some great thing. So also did I endeavor to conceive of Thee, Life of my life, as vast, through infinite spaces, on every side penetrating the whole mass of the universe, and beyond it, every way, through immeasurable boundless spaces; so that the earth should have Thee, the heaven have Thee, all things have Thee, and they be bounded in Thee, and Thou bounded nowhere. For that as the body of this air which is above the earth hindereth not the light of the sun from passing through it, penetrating it, not by bursting or by cutting, but by filling it wholly: so I thought the body not of heaven, air, and sea only, but of the earth too, previous to Thee, so that in all its parts, the greatest as the smallest, it should admit Thy presence by a secret inspiration, within and without, directing all things which Thou hast created. So I guessed, only as unable to conceive aught else, for it was false. For thus should a greater part of the earth contain a greater portion of Thee, and a less, a lesser: and all things should in such sort be full of Thee, that the body of an elephant should contain more of Thee than that of a sparrow, by how much larger it is, and takes up more room; and thus shouldst Thou make the several portions of Thyself present unto the several portions of the world, in fragments, large to the large, petty to the petty. But such art not Thou. But not as yet hadst Thou enlightened my darkness.

(He “sees that the cause of sin lies in free-will, rejects the Manichean heresy, but cannot altogether embrace the doctrine of the Church; recovered from the belief in Astrology, but miserably perplexed about the origin of evil; is led to find in the Platonists the seeds of the doctrine of the Divinity of the WORD, but not of His humiliation; hence he obtains clearer notions of God’s majesty, but, not knowing Christ to be the Mediator, remains estranged from Him; all his doubts removed by the study of Holy Scripture, especially St. Paul.” This Book completes Augustine’s thirty-first year.)

(Dealing with his abandonment of astrology, a naively elaborate proof of the falsity of that science is brought forward, to-wit: By careful planning, two children of widely different parents were observed, who were born at approximately the same time. According to astrology, their horoscopes should be the same, for the stars would obviously be in the same positions

at their simultaneous birth. But one was a slave, the other a successful freeman. In addition, the common phenomenon of twins, born at the same hour or so nearly at the same moment that the stars could not vary enough to be noted, is cited. The twins, according to their horoscopes, should be similarly endowed with abilities, and similarly favored by fortune. Yet this has seldom proved the case.)

BOOK VIII

(Augustine's thirty-second year.)

(i) 1. O my God, let me, with thanksgiving, remember, and confess unto Thee Thy mercies on me.... I had ceased to doubt that there was an incorruptible substance, whence was all other substance; nor did I now desire to be more certain of Thee, but more steadfast in Thee. But for my temporal life, all was wavering, and *my heart had to be purged from the old leaven. The Way*, the Savior Himself, well pleased me, but as yet I shrunk from going, through its straitness....

(The story of the conversion of one Victorinus influences him strongly, and he “longs to devote himself entirely to God, but is mastered by his old habits.”)

(iii) 6. Good God! what takes place in man, that he should more rejoice at the salvation of a soul despaired of, and freed from greater peril, than if there had always been hope of him, or the danger had been less? For so Thou also, merciful Father, *dost more rejoice over one penitent, than over ninety-nine just persons, that need no repentance*. And with much joyfulness do we hear, so often as we hear with what joy *the sheep which had strayed is brought back upon the shepherd's shoulder*, ... and the joy of the solemn service of Thy house forceth to tears, when in Thy house it is read of Thy *younger son, that he was dead, and lived again; had been lost, and is found*....

(iv) 9. Up, Lord, and do; stir us up, and recall us; kindle and draw us; inflame, grow sweet unto us; let us now love, *let us run*. Do not many, out of a deeper hell of blindness than Victorinus, return to Thee, approach, and are enlightened, receiving that *Light*, which *they who receive, receive power from Thee to become Thy sons*?...

(v) 10. ... I was bound, not with another's irons, but by my own iron will. My will the enemy held, and thence had made a chain for me, and bound me. For of a froward will was a lust made; and a lust served, became custom; and custom not resisted became necessity. By which links, as it were, joined together (whence I called it a chain) a hard bondage held me enthralled. But that new will which had begun to be in me, freely to serve Thee, and to wish to enjoy Thee, O God, the only assured pleasantness, was not yet able to overcome my former wilfulness, strengthened by age. Thus did my two wills, one new, and the other old, one carnal, the other spiritual, struggle within me; and by their discord, undid my soul.

11. Thus I understood, by my own experience, what I had read, how *the flesh lusteth against the spirit and the spirit against the flesh....* I, still under service to the earth, refused to fight under Thy banner, and feared as much to be freed of all incumbrances, as we should fear to be encumbered with it. Thus with the baggage of this present world was I held down pleasantly, as in sleep: and the thoughts wherein I meditated on Thee were like the efforts of such as would awake, who yet overcome with a heavy drowsiness are again drenched therein. And as no one would sleep forever, and in all men's sober judgment, waking is better, yet a man for the most part, feeling a heavy lethargy in all his limbs, defers to shake off sleep, and, though half displeased, yet, even after it is time to rise, with pleasure yields to it, so was I assured that much better were it for me to give myself up to Thy charity, than to give myself over to mine own cupidity; but though the former course satisfied me and gained the mastery, the latter pleased me and held me mastered.... *Who then should deliver me thus wretched from the body of this death, but Thy grace only, through Jesus Christ our Lord?*

(Alypius and Nebridius, friends of Augustine, are now with him at Milan. Alypius and another friend relate of Antony, the Egyptian monk, and of how two courtiers were converted by his influence. This rouses Augustine and stirs him deeply.)

(vii) 16. Thou, O Lord, didst turn me round towards myself, taking me from behind my back, where I had placed me, unwilling to observe myself; and setting me before my face, that I might see how foul I was, how crooked and defiled, bespotted and ulcerous. And I beheld and stood aghast; and whither to flee from myself I found not. And if I sought to turn mine eye from off myself, Thou again didst set me over against myself, and thrustedst

me before my eyes, that *I might find out mine iniquity, and hate it*. I had known it, but made as though I saw it not, winked at it, and forgot it.

18. ... What said I not against myself? with what scourges of condemnation lashed I not my soul, that it might follow me, striving to go after Thee! Yet it drew back; refused, but excused not itself. All arguments were spent and confuted; there remained a mute shrinking; and she feared, as she would death, to be restrained from the flux of that custom whereby she was wasting to death.

(viii) 19. ... A little garden there was to our lodging, which we had the use of, as of the whole house; for the master of the house, our host, was not living there. Thither had the tumult of my breast hurried me, where no man might hinder the hot contention wherein I had engaged with myself, until it should end as Thou knewest, I knew not. Only I was healthfully distracted and drying, to live; knowing what evil thing I was, and not knowing what good thing I was shortly to become.... (Alypius, as his intimate friend, goes with him into the garden; otherwise he is quite alone.)

(xi) 25. Soul-sick was I, and tormented, accusing myself much more severely than my wont, rolling and turning me in my chain, till that were wholly broken, whereby I now was but just, but still was, held. And Thou, O Lord, pressedst upon me in my inward parts by a severe mercy, redoubling the lashes of fear and shame, lest I should again give way, and not bursting that same slight remaining tie, it should recover strength, and bind me the faster. For I said within myself, "Be it done now, be it done now." And as I spake, I all but enacted it. I all but did it, and did it not: yet sunk not back to my former state, but kept my stand hard by, and took breath. And I essayed again, and wanted somewhat less of it, and somewhat less, and all but touched and laid hold of it; and yet came not at it, nor touched, nor laid hold of it; hesitating to die to death and to live to life: and the worse whereto I was inured, prevailed more with me than the better, whereto I was unused: and the very moment wherein I was to become other than I was, the nearer it approached me, the greater horror did it strike into me; yet did it not strike me back, nor turned me away, but held me in suspense.

(xii) 28. When a deep consideration had from the secret bottom of my soul drawn together and heaped up all my misery in the sight of my heart; there

arose a mighty storm, bringing a mighty shower of tears. Which that I might pour forth wholly, in its natural expressions, I rose from Alypius: solitude was suggested to me as fitter for the business of weeping; so I retired so far that even his presence could not be a burthen to me. Thus was it then, with me, and he perceived something of it; for something I suppose I had spoken, wherein the tones of my voice appeared choked with weeping, and so had risen up. He then remained where we were sitting, most extremely astonished. I cast myself down I know not how, under a certain fig-tree, giving full vent to my tears; and the floods of mine eyes gushed out, an *acceptable sacrifice to Thee*. And, not indeed in these words, yet to this purpose, spake I much unto Thee: *And Thou, O Lord, how long? how long, Lord, wilt Thou be angry, forever? Remember not our former iniquities*, for I felt that I was held by them. I sent up these sorrowful words: How long? how long, “tomorrow, and tomorrow?” Why not now? why not is there this hour an end to my uncleanness.

29. So was I speaking, and weeping in the most bitter contrition of my heart, when, lo! I heard from a neighboring house a voice, as of boy or girl, I know not, chanting, and oft repeating, “Take up and read; Take up and read.” Instantly, my countenance altered, I began to think most intently, whether children were wont in any kind of play to sing such words: nor could I remember ever to have heard the like. So checking the torrent of my tears, I arose; interpreting it to be no other than a command from God, to open the book, and read the first chapter I should find. For I had heard of Antony, that coming in during the reading of the Gospel, he received the admonition as if what was being read was spoken to him; *Go, sell all that thou hast, and give to the poor, and thou shalt have treasure in heaven, and come and follow me*. And by such oracle he was forthwith converted unto Thee. Eagerly then I returned to the place where Alypius was sitting; for there had I laid the volume of the Apostle, when I arose thence. I seized, opened, and in silence read that section, on which my eyes first fell: *Not in rioting and drunkenness, not in chambering and wantonness, not in strife and envying: but put ye on the Lord Jesus Christ, and make not provision for the flesh,*^[3] in concupiscence. No further would I read; nor need I: for instantly at the end of this sentence, by a light as it were of serenity infused into my heart, all the darkness of doubt vanished away.

30. Then putting my finger between, or some other mark, I shut the volume, and with a calmed countenance made it known to Alypius. And what was wrought in him, which I knew not, he thus showed me. He asked to see what I had read: I showed him; and he looked even further than I had read, and I knew not what followed. This followed, *him that is weak in the faith, receive*; which he applied to himself, and disclosed to me. And by this admonition was he strengthened; and by a good resolution and purpose, and most corresponding to his character, wherein he did always very far differ from me, for the better, without any turbulent delay he joined me. Thence we go into my mother; we tell her; she rejoiceth: we relate in order how it took place; she leaps for joy, and triumpheth, and blesseth Thee, *Who art able to do above that which we ask or think*; for she perceived that Thou hadst given her more for me, than she was wont to beg by her pitiful and most sorrowful groanings. For Thou convertedst me unto Thyself, so that I sought neither wife, nor any hope of this world, standing in that rule of faith where Thou hadst showed me unto her in a vision, so many years before. And Thou didst *convert her mourning into joy*, much more plentiful than she had desired, and in a much more precious and purer way than she erst required, by having grandchildren of my body.

BOOK IX

(i) 1. *O Lord, I am Thy servant; I am Thy servant, and the son of Thy handmaid: Thou hast broken my bonds in sunder. I will offer to Thee the sacrifice of praise....*

(v) 13. The vintage-vacation ended, I gave notice to the Milanese to provide their scholars with another master to sell words to them; for that I had both made choice to serve Thee, and through my difficulty of breathing and pain in my chest, was not equal to the Professorship. And by letters I signified to Thy Prelate, the holy man Ambrose, my former errors and present desires, begging his advice what of Thy Scriptures I had best read, to become readier and fitter for receiving so great grace. He recommended Isaiah the Prophet: I believe, because he above the rest is a more clear foreshower of the Gospel and of the calling of the Gentiles. But I, not understanding the first lesson in him, and imagining the whole to be like it, laid it by, to be resumed when better practised in our Lord's own words.

(vi) 14. Thence, when the time was come, wherein I was to give in my name,^[4] we left the country and returned to Milan.... and we were baptized, and anxiety for our past life vanished from us. Nor was I sated in those days with the wondrous sweetness of considering the depth of Thy counsels concerning the salvation of mankind. How did I weep, in Thy Hymns and Canticles, touched to the quick by the voices of Thy sweet-attuned Church! The voices flowed into mine ears, and the Truth distilled into my heart, whence the affections of my devotion overflowed, and tears ran down, and happy was I therein.

(viii) 17. ... We sought where we might serve Thee most usefully, and were returned to Africa: whitherward being as far as Ostia, my mother departed this life. Much I omit, as hastening much. Receive my confessions and thanksgivings, O my God, for innumerable things whereof I am silent. But I will not omit whatsoever my soul would bring forth concerning that Thy

handmaid, who brought me forth, both in the flesh, that I might be born to this temporal light, and in heart, that I might be born to light eternal. Not her gifts, but Thine in her, would I speak of; for neither did she make nor educate herself. Thou createdst her; nor did her father and mother know what a one should come from them. And the scepter of Thy Christ, the discipline of Thine only Son, in a Christian house, a good member of Thy Church, educated her in Thy fear.

(ix) 19. Brought up modestly and soberly, and made subject rather by Thee to her parents, than by her parents to Thee, so soon as she was of marriageable age, being bestowed upon a husband, she served him as her lord; and did her diligence to win him unto Thee, preaching Thee unto him by her conversation; by which Thou ornamentedst her, making her reverently amiable, and admirable unto her husband....

21. This great gift also Thou bestowedst, O my God, my mercy, upon that good handmaid of Thine, in whose womb Thou createdst me, that between any disagreeing and discordant parties where she was able, she showed herself such a peacemaker, that hearing on both sides most bitter things when the crudities of enmities are breathed out in sour discourses to a present friend against an absent enemy, she never would disclose aught of the one unto the other, but what might tend to their reconciliation. A small good this might appear to me, did I not to my grief know numberless persons who, through some horrible and widespreading contagion of sin, not only disclose to persons mutually angered things said in anger, but add withal things never spoken, whereas to humane humanity it ought to seem a light thing, not to foment or increase ill will by ill words, unless one study withal by good words to quench it. Such was she, Thyself, her most inward Instructor, teaching her in the school of the heart.

22. Finally, her own husband, towards the very end of his earthly life, did she gain unto Thee; nor had she to complain of that in him as a believer, which before he was a believer she had borne from him.... For she had been *the wife of one man, had requited her parents, had governed her house piously, was well reported of for good works, had brought up children, so often travailing in birth of them*, as she saw them swerving from Thee. Lastly, of all of us Thy servants, O Lord, (whom on occasion of Thy own gift Thou sufferest to speak,) us, who before her sleeping in Thee lived united together, having received the grace of Thy baptism, did she so take

care of, as though she had been mother of us all; so served us, as though she had been child to us all.

(x) 23. The day now approaching whereon she was to depart this life, (which day Thou well knewest, we knew not,) it came to pass, Thyself, as I believe, by Thy secret ways so ordering it, that she and I stood alone; leaning in a certain window, which looked into the garden of the house where we now lay, at Ostia; where removed from the din of men, we were recruiting from the fatigues of a long journey, for the voyage. We were discoursing then together, alone, very sweetly; and *forgetting those things which are behind, and reaching forth unto those things which are before*, we were inquiring between ourselves in the presence of the Truth, which Thou art, of what sort the eternal life of the saints was to be, *which eye hath not seen, nor ear heard, nor hath it entered into the heart of man*. But yet we gasped with the mouth of our heart, after those heavenly streams of Thy fountain, *the fountain of life*, which is *with Thee*; that being bedewed thence according to our capacity, we might in some sort meditate upon so high a mystery.

24. And when our discourse was brought to that point, that the very highest delight of the earthly senses, in the very purest material light, was, in respect of the sweetness of that life, not only not worthy of comparison, but not even of mention; we raising up ourselves with a more glowing affection towards the “Self-same,” did by degrees pass through all things bodily, even the very heaven, when sun and moon, and stars shine upon the earth; yea, we were soaring higher yet, by inward musing, and discourse, and admiring of Thy works; and we came to our own minds, and went beyond them, that we might arrive at that region of never-failing plenty, where *Thou feedest Israel* forever with the food of truth, and where life is the *Wisdom by whom all these things are made*, and what have been, and what shall be, and she is not made, but is, as she hath been, and so shall she be ever; yea rather, to “have been,” and “hereafter to be,” are not in her, but only “to be,” seeing she is eternal. For to “have been,” and “to be hereafter,” are not eternal. And while we were discoursing and panting after her, we slightly touched on her with the whole effort of our heart; and we sighed, and there we leave bound *the first fruits of the Spirit*; and returned to vocal expressions of our mouth, where the word spoken was beginning and end. And what is like unto Thy

Word, our Lord, who *endureth in Himself* without becoming old, and *maketh all things new*?

25. We were saying then: If to any the tumult of the flesh were hushed, hushed the images of earth, and waters, and air, hushed also the poles of heaven, yea the very soul be hushed to herself, and by not thinking on self surmount self, hushed all dreams and imaginary revelations, every tongue and every sign, and whatsoever exists only in transition, since if any could hear, all these say, *We made not ourselves, but He made us that abideth forever*—If then having uttered this, they too should be hushed, having roused only our ears to Him who made them, and He alone speak, not by them, but by Himself, that we may hear His Word, not through any tongue of flesh, nor Angel's voice, nor sound of thunder, nor in the dark riddle of similitude, but, might hear Whom in these things we love, might hear His Very Self without these, (as we two now strained ourselves, and in swift thought touched on that Eternal Wisdom, which abideth over all;)—could this be continued on; and other visions of kind far unlike be withdrawn, and this one ravish, and absorb, and wrap up its beholder amid these inward joys, so that life might be forever like that one moment of understanding which now we sighed after; were not this, *Enter into thy Master's joy*? And when shall that be? When *we shall all rise again*, though *we shall not all be changed*?

26. Such things was I speaking, and even if not in this very manner, and these same words, yet, Lord, Thou knowest, that in that day when we were speaking of these things, and this world with all its delights became, as we spake, contemptible to us, my mother said, “Son, for mine own part I have no further delight in anything in this life. What I do here any longer, and to what end I am here, I know not, now that my hopes in this world are accomplished. One thing there was for which I desired to linger for a while in this life, that I might see thee a Catholic Christian before I died. My God hath done this for me more abundantly, that I should now see thee withal, despising earthly happiness, become His servant: what do I here?”

(xi) 27. What answer I made her unto these things, I remember not. For scarce five days after, or not much more, she fell sick of a fever; and in that sickness one day she fell into a swoon, and was for a while withdrawn from these visible things. We hastened round her; but she was soon brought back to her senses; and looking on me and my brother standing by her, said to us

inquiringly, "Where was I?" And then looking fixedly on us, with grief amazed; "Here," saith she, "shall you bury your mother." I held my peace and refrained weeping; but my brother spake something, wishing for her, as the happier lot, that she might die, not in a strange place, but in her own land. Whereat, she with anxious look, checking him with her eyes, for that he still *savored such things*, and then looking upon me; "Behold," saith she, "what he saith:" and soon after to us both, "Lay," she saith, "this body anywhere; let not the care for that any way disquiet you: this only I request, that you would remember me at the Lord's altar, wherever you be." And having delivered this sentiment in what words she could, she held her peace, being exercised by her growing sickness.

28. But I, considering Thy gifts, Thou unseen God, which Thou instillest into the hearts of Thy faithful ones, whence wondrous fruits do spring, did rejoice and give thanks to Thee, recalling what I before knew, how careful and anxious she had ever been, as to her place of burial, which she had provided and prepared for herself by the body of her husband. For because they had lived in great harmony together, she also wished (so little can the human mind embrace things divine) to have this addition to that happiness, and to have it remembered among men, that after her pilgrimage beyond the seas, what was earthly of this united pair had been permitted to be united beneath the same earth. But when this emptiness had through the fullness of Thy goodness begun to cease in her heart, I knew not, and rejoiced admiring what she had so disclosed to me; though indeed in that our discourse also in the window, when she said, "What do I here any longer?" there appeared no desire of dying in her own country. I heard afterwards also, that when we were now at Ostia, she with a mother's confidence, when I was absent, one day discoursed with certain of my friends about the contempt of this life, and the blessing of death: and when they were amazed at such courage which Thou hadst given to a woman, and asked, "Whether she were not afraid to leave her body so far from her own city?" she replied, "Nothing is far to God; nor was it to be feared lest at the end of the world, He should not recognize whence He were to raise me up." On the ninth day then of her sickness, and the fifty-sixth year of her age, and the three and thirtieth of mine, was that religious and holy soul freed from the body.

(xii) 29. I closed her eyes; and there flowed withal a mighty sorrow into my heart; which was overflowing into tears; mine eyes at the same time, by the

violent command of my mind, drank up their fountain wholly dry; and woe was me in such a strife! But when she breathed her last, a boy burst out into a loud lament; then, checked by us all, held his peace. In like manner also a childish feeling in me, which was, through my heart's youthful voice, finding its vent in weeping, was checked and silenced. For we thought it not fitting to solemnize that funeral with tearful lament, and groanings: for thereby do they for the most part express grief for the departed, as though unhappy, or altogether dead; whereas she was neither unhappy in her death, nor altogether dead. Of this we were assured on good grounds, the testimony of her good conversation and her *faith unfeigned*.

30. What then was it which did grievously pain me within, but a fresh wound wrought through the sudden wrench of that most sweet and dear custom of living together? I joyed indeed in her testimony, when, in that her last sickness, mingling her endearments with my acts of duty, she called me "dutiful," and mentioned, with great affection of love, that she never had heard any harsh or reproachful sound uttered by my mouth against her. But yet, O my God, Who madest us, what comparison is there betwixt that honor that I paid to her, and her slavery for me? Being then forsaken of so great comfort in her, my soul was wounded, and that life rent asunder as it were, which, of hers and mine together, had been made but one.

31. The boy then being stifled from weeping, Euodius took up the Psalter, and began to sing, our whole house answering him, the Psalm, *I will sing of mercy and judgment to Thee, O Lord*. But hearing what we were doing, many brethren and religious women came together; and whilst they (whose office it was) made ready for the burial, as the manner is, I (in a part of the house where I might properly), together with those who thought not fit to leave me, discoursed upon something fitting the time; and by this balm of truth assuaged that torment, known to Thee, they unknowing and listening intently, and conceiving me to be without all sense of sorrow. But in Thy ears, where none of them heard, I blamed the weakness of my feelings, and refrained my flood of grief, which gave way a little unto me; but again came, as with a tide, yet not so as to burst out into tears, nor to a change of countenance; still I knew what I was keeping down in my heart. And being very much displeased that these human things had such power over me, which in the due order and appointment of our natural condition must needs

come to pass, with a new grief I grieved for my grief, and was thus worn by a double sorrow.

32. And behold, the corpse was carried to the burial; we went and returned without tears. For neither in those prayers which we poured forth unto Thee, when the sacrifice of our ransom was offered for her, when now the corpse was by the grave's side, as the manner there is, previous to its being laid therein, did I weep even during those prayers; yet was I the whole day in secret heavily sad, and with troubled mind prayed Thee, as I could, to heal my sorrow, yet Thou didst not; impressing, I believe, upon my memory by this one instance, how strong is the bond of all habit, even upon a soul which now feeds upon no deceiving Word. It seemed also good to me to go and bathe, having heard that the bath had its name from the Greek word implying a driving of sadness from the mind. And this also I confess unto Thy mercy, *Father of the fatherless*, that I bathe, and was the same as before I bathed. For the bitterness of sorrow could not exude out of my heart. Then I slept, and woke up again, and found my grief not a little softened; and as I was alone in my bed, I remembered those true verses of Thy Ambrose. For Thou art the

Maker of all, the Lord,
And Ruler of the height,
Who, robing day in light, hast poured
Soft slumbers o'er the night,
That to our limbs the power
Of toil may be renew'd,
And hearts be rais'd that sink and cower,
And sorrows be subdu'd.

33. And then by little and little I recovered my former thoughts of Thy handmaid, her holy conversation towards Thee, her holy tenderness and observance toward us, whereof I was suddenly deprived: and I was minded to weep in Thy sight, for her and for myself, in her behalf and in my own. And I gave way to the tears which I before restrained, to overflow as much as they desired; reposing my heart upon them; and it found rest in them, for it was in Thy ears, not in those of man, who would have scornfully interpreted my weeping. And now, Lord, in writing I confess it unto Thee. Read it, who will, and interpret it, how he will: and if he finds sin therein,

that I wept my mother for a small portion of an hour, (the mother who for the time was dead to mine eyes, who had for many years wept for me, that I might live in Thine eyes,) let him not deride me; but rather, if he be one of large charity, let him weep himself for my sins unto Thee, the Father of all the brethren of Thy Christ.

(xiii) 37. May she rest then in peace with the husband, before and after whom she had never any; whom she obeyed, *with patience bringing forth fruit* unto Thee, that she might win him also unto Thee. And inspire, O Lord my God, inspire Thy servants my brethren, Thy sons my masters, whom with voice, and heart, and pen I serve, that so many as shall read these Confessions may at Thy Altar remember Monnica Thy handmaid, with Patricius, her sometimes husband, by whose bodies Thou broughtest me into this life, how, I know not. May they with devout affection remember my parents in this transitory light, my brethren under Thee our Father in our Catholic Mother, and my fellow citizens in that eternal Jerusalem, which Thy pilgrim people sigheth after from their Exodus, even unto their return thither. That so my mother's last request of me may, through my confessions, more than through my prayers, be, through the prayers of many, more abundantly fulfilled to her.

BOOK X

(“Having in the former books spoken of himself before his receiving the grace of Baptism, in this Augustine confesses what he then was. But first he inquires by what faculty we can know God at all, whence he enlarges on the mysterious character of the memory, wherein God, being made known, dwells, but which could not discover Him. Then he examines his own trials under the triple division of temptation, ‘lust of the flesh, lust of the eyes, and pride;’ what Christian continency prescribes as to each. On Christ, the Only Mediator, who heals and will heal all infirmities.” The sections on the nature of memory are the most interesting, and surprizing, too, in the light of modern psychology.)

(viii) 12. I come to the fields and spacious palaces of my memory, where are the treasures of innumerable images, brought into it from things of all sorts perceived by the senses. There is stored up, whatsoever besides we think, either by enlarging or diminishing, or any other way varying those things which the sense hath come to; and whatever else hath been committed and laid up, which forgetfulness hath not yet swallowed up and buried. When I enter there, I require what I will to be brought forth, and something instantly comes; others must be longer sought after, which are fetched, as it were, out of some inner receptacle; others rush out in troops, and while one thing is desired and required, they start forth, as who should say, “Is it perchance I?” These I drive away with the hand of my heart from the face of my remembrance; until what I wished for be unveiled, and appear in sight, out of its secret place. Other things come up readily, in unbroken order, as they are called for; those in front making way for the following; and as they make way, they are hidden from sight, ready to come when I will. All which takes place, when I repeat a thing by heart.

13. There are all things preserved distinctly and under general heads, each having entered by its own avenue: as light, and all colors and forms of

bodies, by the eyes; by the ears all sorts of sounds; all smells by the avenue of the nostrils; all tastes by the mouth; and by the sensation of the whole body, what is hard or soft; hot or cold; smooth or rugged; heavy or light; either outwardly or inwardly to the body. All these doth that great harbor of the memory receive in her numberless secret and inexpressible windings, to be forthcoming, and brought out at need; each entering in by his own gate, and there laid up. Nor yet do the things themselves enter in; only the images of the things perceived are there in readiness, for thought to recall. Which images, how they are formed, who can tell, though it doth plainly appear by which sense each hath been brought in and stored up? For even while I dwell in darkness and silence, in my memory I can produce colors, if I will, and discern betwixt black and white, and what others I will: nor yet do sounds break in, and disturb the image drawn in by my eyes, which I am reviewing, though they also are there, lying dormant, and laid up, as it were, apart. For these too I call for, and forthwith they appear. And though my tongue be still, and my throat mute, so can I sing as much as I will; nor do those images of colors, which notwithstanding be there, intrude themselves and interrupt, when another store is called for, which flowed in by the ears. So the other things, piled in and up by the other senses, I recall at my pleasure. Yea, I discern the breath of lilies from violets, though smelling nothing; and I prefer honey to sweet wine, smooth before rugged, at the time neither tasting, nor handling, but remembering only.

14. These things do I within, in that vast court of my memory. For there are present with me heaven, earth, sea, and whatever I could think on therein, besides what I have forgotten. There also meet I with myself, and recall myself, and when, where, and what I have done, and under what feelings. There be all which I remember, either on my own experience, or others' credit. Out of the same store do I myself with the past continually combine fresh and fresh likenesses of things, which I have experienced, or, from what I have experienced, have believed: and thence again infer future actions, events and hopes, and all these again I reflect on, as present.... I speak to myself: and when I speak, the images of all I speak of are present, out of the same treasury of memory; nor would I speak of any thereof, were the images wanting.

15. Great is this force of memory, excessive great, O my God; a large and boundless chamber! who ever sounded the bottom thereof? yet is this a

power of mine, and belongs unto my nature; nor do I myself comprehend all that I am. Therefore is the mind too strait to contain itself....

(ix) 16. Here also is all learnt of the liberal sciences and as yet unforgotten; removed as it were to some inner place, which is yet no place: nor are they the images thereof, but the things themselves.... For some things are not transmitted into the memory, but their images only are with an admirable swiftness caught up, and stored as it were in wondrous cabinets, and thence wonderfully by the act of remembering brought forth.

(xii) 19. The memory containeth also reasons and laws innumerable of numbers and dimensions, none of which hath any bodily sense impressed; seeing they have neither color, nor sound, nor taste, nor smell, nor touch....

(xiv) 21. The same memory contains also the affections of my mind, not in the same manner that my mind itself contains them, when it feels them; but far otherwise, according to a power of its own. For without rejoicing I remember myself to have joyed; and without sorrow do I recollect my past sorrow. And that I once feared, I review without fear; and without desire call to mind a past desire. Sometimes, on the contrary, with joy do I remember my fore-past sorrow, and with sorrow, joy....

(xvi) 24. What, when I name forgetfulness, and withal recognize what I name? whence should I recognize it, did I not remember it? I speak not of the sound of the name, but of the thing which it signifies: which if I had forgotten, I could not recognize what that sound signifies. When then I remember memory, memory itself is, through itself, present with itself: but when I remember forgetfulness, there are present both memory and forgetfulness; memory whereby I remember, forgetfulness which I remember. But what is forgetfulness, but the privation of memory? How then is it present that I remember it, since when present I cannot remember? But if what we remember we hold it in memory, yet, unless we did remember forgetfulness, we could never at the hearing of the name, recognize the thing thereby signified, then forgetfulness is retained by memory. Present then it is, that we forget not, and being so, we forget. It is to be understood from this, that forgetfulness, when we remember it, is not present to the memory by itself, but by its image: because if it were present by itself, it would not cause us to remember, but to forget. Who now shall search out this? who shall comprehend how it is?

25. Lord, I, truly, toil therein, yea and toil in myself; I am become a heavy soil requiring over much *sweat of the brow*. For we are not now searching out the regions of heaven, or measuring the distances of the stars, or inquiring the balancings of the earth. It is I myself who remember, I the mind. It is not so wonderful if what I myself am not, be far from me. But what is nearer to me than myself? And lo, the force of mine own memory is not understood by me; though I cannot so much as name myself without it. For what shall I say, when it is clear to me that I remember forgetfulness? Shall I say that that is not in my memory, which I remember? or shall I say that forgetfulness is for this purpose in my memory, that I might not forget? Both were most absurd. What third way is there? How can I say that the image of forgetfulness is retained by my memory, not forgetfulness itself, when I remember it? How could I say this either, seeing that when the image of anything is impressed on the memory, the thing itself must needs be first present, whence that image may be impressed? For thus do I remember Carthage, thus all places where I have been, thus men's faces whom I have seen, and things reported by the other senses; thus the health or sickness of the body. For when these things were present, my memory received from them images, which, being present with me, I might look on and bring back in my mind when I remember them in their absence. If then this forgetfulness is retained in the memory through its image, not through itself, then plainly itself was once present, that its image might be taken. But when it was present, how did it write its image in the memory, seeing that forgetfulness by its presence effaces even what it finds already noted? And yet, in whatever way, although that way be past conceiving and explaining, yet certain am I that I remember forgetfulness itself also, whereby what we remember is effaced.

(xvii) 26. ... I will pass even beyond this power of mine which is called memory: yea, I will pass beyond it, that I may approach unto Thee, O sweet Light. What sayest Thou to me? See, I am mounting up through my mind towards Thee who abidest above me. Yea I will now pass beyond this power of mine which is called memory, desirous to arrive at Thee, whence Thou mayest be arrived at; and to cleave unto Thee, whence one may cleave unto Thee. For even beasts and birds have memory; else could they not return to their dens and nests, nor many other things they are used unto: nor indeed could they be used to anything, but by memory. I will pass then beyond memory, that I may arrive at Him who hath separated me from the four-

footed beasts and made me wiser than the fowls of the air, I will pass beyond memory also, and where shall I find Thee, Thou truly good and certain sweetness? And where shall I find Thee?...

(xxiv) 35. See what a space I have gone over in my memory seeking Thee, O Lord; and I have not found Thee without it. Nor have I found anything concerning Thee, but what I have kept in memory ever since I learnt Thee. For since I learnt Thee, I have not forgotten Thee. For where I found Truth, there found I my God, the Truth Itself; which since I learnt, I have not forgotten. Since then I learned Thee, Thou residest in my memory; and there do I find Thee, when I call Thee to remembrance, and delight in Thee. These be my holy delights, which Thou hast given me in Thy mercy, having regard to my poverty.

(xxv) 36. But where in my memory residest Thou, O Lord, where residest Thou there? what manner of lodging hast Thou framed for Thee? what manner of sanctuary hast Thou builded for Thee? Thou hast given this honor to my memory, to reside in it; but in what quarter of it Thou residest, that am I considering. For in thinking on Thee, I passed beyond such parts of it as the beasts also have, for I found Thee not there among the images of corporeal things: and I came to those parts to which I committed the affections of my mind, nor found Thee there. And I entered into the very seat of my mind, (which it hath in my memory, inasmuch as the mind remembers itself also,) neither wert Thou there: for as Thou art not a corporeal image, nor the affection of a living being; (as when we rejoice, condole, desire, fear, remember, forget, or the like;) so neither art Thou the mind itself; because Thou art the Lord God of the mind; and all these are changed, but Thou remainest unchangeable over all, and yet hast vouchsafed to dwell in my memory, since I learnt Thee. And why seek I now, in what place whereof Thou dwellest, as if there were places therein? Sure I am, that in it Thou dwellest, since I have remembered Thee, ever since I learnt Thee, and there I find Thee, when I call Thee to remembrance.

(xxvi) 37. Where then did I find Thee, that I might learn Thee? For in my memory Thou wert not, before I learned Thee. Where then did I find Thee, that I might learn Thee, but in Thee above me? Place there is none; *we go backward and forward*, and there is no place. Everywhere, O Truth, dost Thou give audience to all who ask counsel of Thee, and at once answerest all, though on manifold matters they ask Thy counsel. Clearly dost Thou

answer, though all do not clearly hear. All consult Thee on what they will, though they hear not always what they will. He is thy best servant who looks not so much to hear that from Thee which himself willeth; as rather to will that which from Thee he heareth.

BOOK XI

(“Augustine breaks off the history of the mode whereby God led him to holy Orders, in order to ‘confess’ God’s mercies in opening to him the Scripture. Moses is not to be understood, but in Christ, not even the first words *In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth*. Answer to cavillers who asked, what did God before He created the heaven and the earth, and whence willed He at length to make them, whereas He did not make them before. Inquiry into the nature of Time.”)

(It is in considering the question of God’s actions before the Creation, and of his delay in not bringing about the Creation sooner, that Augustine comes to consider the nature of Time.)

(xiv) 17. At no time then hadst Thou not made anything, because time itself Thou madest. And no times are coeternal with Thee, because Thou abidest; but if they abode, they should not be times. For what is time? Who can readily and briefly explain this? Who can even in thought comprehend it, so as to utter a word about it? But what in discourse do we mention more familiarly and knowingly than time? And we understand when we speak of it; we understand also when we hear it spoken of by another. What then is time? If no one asks me, I know: if I wish to explain it to one that asketh, I know not: yet I say boldly that I know, that if nothing passed away, time past were not; and if nothing were coming, a time to come were not; and if nothing were, time present were not. Those two times then, past and to come, how are they, seeing the past now is not, and that to come is not yet? But the present, should it always be present, and never pass into time past, verily it should not be time, but eternity. If time present (if it is to be time) only cometh into existence, because it passeth into time past, how can we say that either this is, whose cause of being is, that it shall not be; so, namely, that we cannot truly say that time is, but because it is tending not to be?

(xv) 18. And yet we say, “a long time” and “a short time;” still, only of time past or to come. A long time past (for example) we call an hundred years since; and a long time to come, an hundred years hence. But a short time past, we call (suppose) ten days since; and a short time to come, ten days hence. But in what sense is that long or short, which is not? For the past is not now; and the future is not yet. Let us not then say “it is long”; but of the past, “it hath been long”; and of the future, “it will be long.”

(But the past, being no more, cannot be long, for what ceases to be, ceases also to be long. Yet can the present be long? Say, a hundred years? No, for a hundred years is never present at once, nor even a month, or a day, or an hour—only the smallest conceivable instant is present. What then of the future? The future is not yet, so is not long; and when the future is here, it is the present, which has been shown to be the briefest conceivable instant.)

(xvi) 21. And yet, Lord, we perceive intervals of times, and compare them, and say some are shorter and others longer. We measure also how much longer or shorter this time is than that; and we answer, “This is double, or treble; and that, but once, or only just so much as that.” But we measure times as they are passing, by perceiving them; but past, which now are not, or the future, which are not yet, who can measure? unless a man shall presume to say that can be measured which is not. When then time is passing, it may be perceived and measured; but when it is past, it cannot, because it is not.

(xx) 26. What now is clear and plain is that neither things to come nor past are. Nor is it properly said, “there be three times, past, present, and to come”: yet perchance it might be properly said, “there be three times; a present of things past, a present of things present, and a present of things future.” For these three do exist in some sort, in the soul, but elsewhere do I not see them; present of things past, memory; present of things present, sight; present of things future, expectation. If thus we be permitted to speak, I see three times, and I confess there are three. Let it be said too, “there be three times, past, present, and to come”: in our incorrect way. See, I object not, nor gainsay, nor find fault, if what is so said be but understood, that neither what is to be, now is, nor what is past. For but few things are there which we speak properly, most things improperly; still the things intended are understood.

(xxi) 27. I said then even now, we measure times as they pass, in order to be able to say, this time is twice so much as that one; or, this is just so much as that; and so of any other parts of time, which be measurable. Wherefore, as I said, we measure times as they pass....

(xxiii) 30. I desire to know the force and nature of time, by which we measure the motions of bodies, and say (for example) this motion is twice as long as that....

(xxiv) 31. Dost Thou bid me assent, if any define time to be “motion of a body?” Thou dost not bid me. For that no body is moved, but in time, I hear; this Thou sayest; but that the motion of a body is time, I hear not; Thou sayest it not.

(For it is quite possible to measure the time a body stands still, as, for instance, in the expression: “It stood still twice as long as it moved.” Time, therefore, is not the motion of a body.)

(xxvi) 33. Does not my soul most truly confess unto Thee that I do measure times?... That I measure time, I know; and yet I measure not time to come, for it is not yet; nor present, because it is not protracted by any space; nor past, because it now is not. What then do I measure? Times passing, not past? for so I said.

(Time is measured between the beginning and end of something, as between the beginning and end of a sound. The sound cannot be measured before it begins, while it is sounding, or after it has stopped. But, by noting the beginning and ending, the interval can be determined.)

(xxvii) 36. It is in thee, my mind, that I measure times. Interrupt me not, that is, interrupt not thyself with the tumults of thy impressions. In thee I measure times; the impression, which things as they pass by cause in thee, remains even when they are gone; this it is which still present, I measure, not the things which pass by to make this impression. This I measure, when I measure times. Either then this is time, or I do not measure times. What when we measure silence, and say that this silence hath held as long time as did that voice? do we not stretch out our thought to the measure of a voice, as if it sounded? that so we may be able to report of the intervals of silence in a given space of time?...

(xxviii) 37. ... It is not future time that is long, for as yet it is not: but a “long future” is “a long expectation of the future,” nor is it time past, which now is not, that is long; but a long past is “a long memory of the past.”

38. I am about to repeat a Psalm that I know. Before I begin, my expectation is extended over the whole; but when I have begun, how much soever of it I shall separate off into the past, is extended along my memory; thus the life of this action of mine is divided between my memory as to what I have repeated, and expectation as to what I am about to repeat; but “consideration” is present with me, that through it what was future may be conveyed over, so as to become past. Which the more it is done again and again, so much the more the expectation being shortened, is the memory enlarged; till the whole expectation be at length exhausted, when the whole action being ended, shall have passed into memory. And this which takes place in the whole Psalm, the same takes place in each several portion of it, and each several syllable; the same holds in that longer action, whereof this Psalm may be a part; the same holds in the whole life of man, whereof all the actions of man are parts; the same holds through the whole age of the sons of men, whereof all the lives of men are parts.

(xxx) 40. And now I will stand and become firm in Thee, in my mold, Thy truth; nor will I endure the questions of men, who by a penal disease thirst for more than they can contain, and say, “what did God before He *made heaven and earth*?” “Or, how came it into His mind to make anything, having never before made anything?” Give them, O Lord, well to bethink themselves what they say, and to find that “never” cannot be predicated, when “time” is not. This then that He is said “never to have made;” what else is it to say, then “in ‘no time’ to have made?” Let them see therefore that time cannot be without created being, and cease to *speak* that *vanity*. May they also be *extended towards those things which are before*; and understand Thee before all times, the eternal Creator of all times, and that no times be coeternal with Thee, nor any creature, even if there be any creature before all time.

BOOK XII

(“Augustine proceeds to comment on Genesis i, 1, and explains the ‘heaven’ to mean that spiritual and incorporeal creation, which cleaves to God unintermittingly, always beholding His countenance; ‘earth,’ the formless matter whereof the corporeal creation was afterwards formed. He does not reject, however, other interpretations, which he adduces, but rather confesses that such is the depth of Holy Scripture that manifold senses may and ought to be extracted from it, and that whatever truth can be obtained from its words, does, in fact, lie concealed in them.”)

(Most of this Book and some of the next is devoted to a discussion of the first verse of the first chapter of Genesis, deriving a great many possible interpretations of the words of Moses, and considering carefully their respective meanings and bearings upon the Scripture and upon man’s attitude toward the Scripture and toward God. That it is possible so to derive many meanings is to Augustine a proof of the greatness of the Scriptures, as he summarizes in the following brief extract.)

(xxvii) 37. For as a fountain with a narrow compass is more plentiful, and supplies a tide for more streams over larger spaces, than any one of those streams, which, after a wide interval, is derived from the same fountain; so the relation of that dispenser of Thine, which was to benefit many who were to discourse thereon, does out of a narrow scantling of language overflow into streams of clearest truth, whence every man may draw out for himself such truth as he can upon these subjects, one, one truth, another, another, by larger circumlocutions of discourse....

BOOK XIII

(“Continuation of the exposition of Genesis i, 1; it contains the mystery of the Trinity, and a type of the formation, extension, and support of the Church.”)

(xxxii) 47. Thanks to Thee, O Lord. We behold *the heaven and earth*, whether the corporeal part, superior and inferior, or the spiritual and corporeal creature; and in the adorning of these parts, whereof the universal pile of the world, or rather the universal creation, doth consist, we see *light* made, and *divided from the darkness*. We see the *firmament of heaven*, whether that primary body of the world, *between the* spiritual upper waters *and the* inferior corporeal waters, or (since this also is called heaven) this space of air through which wander the fowls of heaven, *betwixt those waters* which are in vapors borne above them, and in clear nights distil down in dew; *and those heavier waters* which flow along the earth. We behold a face of *waters gathered together* in the fields of *the sea*; and *the dry land* both void, and formed so as to be visible and harmonized, yea and the matter of herbs and trees. We behold *the lights* shining from above, *the sun* to suffice for *the day*, *the moon and the stars* to cheer *the night*; and that by all these, *times* should be marked and signified. We behold on all sides a moist element, replenished with fishes, beasts, and birds; because the grossness of the air, which bears up the flights of birds, thickeneth itself by the exhalation of the waters. We behold the face of the earth decked out with earthly creatures, and *man, created after Thy image and likeness*, even through that Thy very *image and likeness*, (that is the power of reason and understanding), set over all irrational creatures. And as in his soul there is one power which has dominion by directing, another made subject, that it might obey; so was there for the man, corporeally also, made a woman, who in the mind of her reasonable understanding should have a parity of nature, but in the sex of her body, should be in like manner subject to the sex of her husband, as the appetite of doing is fain to conceive the skill of right-doing, from the reason of the mind. These things we behold, and they are severally *good*, and altogether *very good*.

(xxxiii) 48. Let Thy works praise Thee, that we may love Thee; and let us love Thee, that Thy works may praise Thee, which from time have beginning and ending, rising and setting, growth and decay, form and privation. They have then their succession of morning and evening, part secretly, part apparently; for they were made of nothing, by Thee, not of Thee; not of any matter not Thine, or that was before, but of matter concreated, (that is, at the same time created by Thee), because to its state *without form*, Thou without any interval of time didst give form. For seeing the matter of *heaven and earth* is one thing, and the form another, Thou madest the matter of merely nothing, but the form of the world out of the matter *without form*; yet both together, so that the form should follow the matter, without any interval of delay.

(xxxiv) 49. We have also examined what Thou willedst to be shadowed forth, whether by the creation, or the relation of things in such an order. And we have seen, that things singly *are good*, and together *very good*, in Thy word, in Thy Only-Begotten, both *heaven and earth*, the Head and the body of the Church, in Thy predestination before all times, without *morning and evening*. But when Thou beganest to execute in time the things predestinated, to the end Thou mightest reveal hidden things, and rectify our *disorders*; for our sins hung over us, and we had sunk into the *dark deep*, and Thy good *Spirit was borne* over us, to help us *in due season*; and Thou didst *justify the ungodly*, and *dividest* them from the wicked; and Thou *madest the firmament* of authority of Thy Book between those placed *above*, who were to be docile unto Thee, and those *under*, who were to be subject to them: and Thou *gatheredst together* the society of unbelievers *into one* conspiracy, that the zeal of the faithful might appear, and they might *bring forth* works of mercy, even distributing to the poor their earthly riches, to obtain heavenly. And after this didst Thou kindle certain *lights in the firmament*, Thy Holy ones, having *the word of life*; and shining with an eminent authority set on high through spiritual gifts; after that again, for the initiation of the unbelieving Gentiles, didst Thou out of corporeal matter produce the Sacraments, and visible miracles, and forms of words according to the firmament of Thy Book, by which the faithful should be *blessed* and *multiplied*. Next didst Thou form the *living soul* of the faithful, through affections well ordered by the vigor of continency: and after that, the mind subjected to Thee alone and needing to imitate no human authority, hast Thou renewed *after Thy image and likeness*; and didst

subject its rational actions to the excellency of the understanding, as *the* woman to the man; and to all Offices of Thy Ministry, necessary for the perfecting of the faithful in this life, Thou willedst, that for their temporal uses, good things, fruitful to themselves in time to come, be given by the same faithful. *All* these we see, and they are *very good*, because Thou seest them in us, Who hast given unto us Thy Spirit, by which we might see them, and in them love Thee.

(xxxv) 50. O Lord God, *give peace unto us*: (for Thou hast given us all things); the peace of rest, the peace of the Sabbath, which hath no evening. For all this most goodly array of things *very good*, having finished their courses, is to pass away, for in them there *was morning and evening*.

(xxxvi) 51. But the seventh day hath no evening, nor hath it setting; because Thou hast sanctified it to an everlasting continuance; that that which Thou didst *after Thy works which were very good, resting the seventh day*, although Thou madest them in unbroken rest, that may the voice of Thy Book announce beforehand unto us, that we also after our works, (therefore, *very good*, because Thou hast given them us), shall *rest* in Thee also in the Sabbath of eternal life.

(xxxvii) 52. For then shalt Thou so rest in us, as now Thou workest in us; and so shall that be Thy rest through us, as these are Thy works through us. But Thou, Lord, ever workest, and art ever at rest. Nor dost Thou see in time, nor art moved in time, nor retest in a time; and yet Thou makest things seen in time, yea the times themselves, and the rest which results from time.

(xxxviii) 53. We therefore see these things which Thou madest, because they are: but they are, because Thou seest them. And we see without, that they are, and within, that they are good, but Thou sawest them there, when made, where Thou sawest them, yet to be made. And we were at a later time moved to do well, after our hearts had conceived of Thy spirit; but in the former time we were moved to do evil, forsaking Thee; but Thou, the One, the Good God, didst never cease doing good. And we also have some *good works*, of Thy gift, but not eternal; *after them* we trust to *rest* in Thy great *hallowing*. But Thou, being the Good which needeth no good, art ever at rest, because Thy rest is Thou Thyself. And what man can teach man to understand this? or what Angel, an Angel? or what Angel, a man? Let it be

asked of Thee, *sought* in Thee, *knocked* for at Thee; so, so shall it be *received*, so shall it be *found*, so shall it be *opened*. Amen.

GRATIAS TIBI DOMINE.

Footnotes

- [1](#). The preacher who influenced Augustine's conversion and baptized him. (see Introduction).
- [2](#). "He alludes here to that devout manner of the Eastern ancients, who used to lie flat on their faces in prayer."
- [3](#). Romans xiii, 13-14.
- [4](#). To be baptized at Easter, they handed in their names before the second Sunday in Lent.

- Transcriber's Notes:
 - Footnotes have been collected at the end of the text, and are linked for ease of reference.

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